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Celebration of Life Planning Checklist

A gentle guide for gathering family and friends to honor someone you love

Planning a celebration of life is hard, and you do not have to do it perfectly or all at once. This checklist breaks it into small steps and gives you places to write things down, so you can share the work with people who want to help. Take what is useful and leave the rest.

INSIDE

1. The First Days
2. Planning Timeline
3. Venue Options
4. Program and Order of Service
5. Memory Table Ideas
6. Repast Food Amounts
7. Who Does What
8. Budget Split
9. Gathering Worksheet



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PART 1

The First Days

There is no right order. Do what you can, and ask for help with the rest.

RIGHT AWAY

- [ ] Choose one or two people to be the main contacts for family and vendors.
- [ ] Gather important documents such as the will, insurance papers, and any written wishes.
- [ ] Ask whether your loved one left wishes for a service, burial, or cremation.
- [ ] Contact the funeral home or cremation provider if you are working with one.
- [ ] Decide on a date range for the gathering, allowing time for out-of-town family.
- [ ] Write down what you decide so you do not have to repeat it.
- [ ] Decide whether the gathering will be private, open to all, or invitation only.
- [ ] Ask the family which religious or cultural customs they would like included.
- [ ] Check on any wishes about flowers, music, or readings.

TELLING PEOPLE

- [ ] Make a short list of the people who should hear first.
- [ ] Ask a trusted friend or relative to help spread the word.
- [ ] Write a brief message with the date, time, and place once they are set.
- [ ] Share the request for flowers, donations, or no gifts, if you have one.
- [ ] Post a notice if you wish, and ask a helper to manage replies.
- [ ] Consider a short phone tree so no one has to make every call.
- [ ] Let work, school, and community groups know.

TAKE CARE OF YOURSELF

- [ ] Eat something and drink water.
- [ ] Accept offers of meals, rides, and childcare.
- [ ] Assign a helper to answer calls and messages.
- [ ] Plan a quiet moment before the gathering.
- [ ] Remember that there is no single right way to grieve.

PART 2

Planning Timeline

Celebrations of life are often held within one to four weeks, but timing is up to your family.

First 1 to 3 days

- [ ] Choose a date range and gather the immediate family to decide on the style of gathering.
- [ ] Contact potential venues and ask about availability.
- [ ] Ask a few helpers to take on specific roles.
- [ ] Confirm the plan for burial, cremation, or memorial.

Days 3 to 7

- [ ] Book the venue and confirm the time, length, and setup rules.
- [ ] Choose the officiant, celebrant, or family member who will lead.
- [ ] Order food or arrange for family and friends to contribute.
- [ ] Reserve tables, chairs, linens, and any needed tent.
- [ ] Send word to guests with a simple message.
- [ ] Check parking, ramps, and seating for guests with mobility needs.
- [ ] Plan an alternate if the weather affects an outdoor space.

One week out

- [ ] Finalize the program and who will speak.
- [ ] Gather photos and keepsakes for display.
- [ ] Arrange music, a slideshow, or a playlist.
- [ ] Confirm the final headcount with the venue and food provider.
- [ ] Plan parking and accessibility for older guests.

The day before

- [ ] Confirm delivery and setup times for rentals.
- [ ] Print programs, photos, or memory cards.
- [ ] Set up the memory table or display if you have access to the venue.
- [ ] Share the schedule with helpers.
- [ ] Pack tissues, water, and a small emergency kit.
- [ ] Confirm who is bringing food and where it will be stored.
- [ ] Charge phones, speakers, and the slideshow device.

Day of

- [ ] Arrive early and walk the space with a helper.
- [ ] Assign a greeter at the door and someone to manage the guest book.
- [ ] Keep the schedule flexible and give speakers extra time.
- [ ] Have someone check on older guests and young children.
- [ ] Plan a quiet space for family to step away.

After

- [ ] Collect flowers, photos, and keepsakes.
- [ ] Return rentals and clean the venue.
- [ ] Send thank-you notes when you feel ready.
- [ ] Share photos and the program with those who could not attend.

PART 3

Venue Options

The right place is one that feels comfortable to your family and fits your guests.

Venue type	Good for	Things to ask
Home or backyard	Small, informal gatherings; a familiar and personal setting	Parking, restrooms, space, weather plan, chairs and tables
Place of worship or community hall	Religious or community-based gatherings	Availability, fees, kitchen access, capacity
Restaurant private room	Simple food service and easy cleanup	Minimums, menu options, setup time
Park shelter or garden	Outdoor gatherings in warmer months	Permits, restrooms, weather, tent options
Banquet hall or event space	Larger groups, formal meals	Capacity, rentals included, catering rules
Funeral home chapel or reception room	Convenient and staffed	Timing, food options, capacity
Meaningful location (a favorite spot)	A personal, symbolic gathering	Permissions, accessibility, restrooms, seating

PART 4

Program and Order of Service

A short program is often enough. Most gatherings run 60 to 90 minutes before food and mingling.

OPENING

- [ ] Welcome from a family member or celebrant.
- [ ] Music as guests arrive.
- [ ] A moment of silence or a short reading.
- [ ] Brief explanation of the plan for the gathering.
- [ ] Ask a helper to hand out programs and tissues as guests arrive.

REMEMBERING

- [ ] Two or three prepared speakers.
- [ ] Open-mic time for guests to share a short memory.
- [ ] A slideshow or video with favorite photos.
- [ ] A favorite poem, song, or passage.
- [ ] A tribute from children or grandchildren.
- [ ] Give speakers a gentle time limit of three to five minutes.
- [ ] Ask speakers to send a copy of their words to a helper in case they need someone to read them aloud.

CLOSING

- [ ] Closing words or a blessing.
- [ ] A favorite song or a group toast.
- [ ] Invitation to share food and stories.
- [ ] Notes on where to find the memory table and guest book.
- [ ] Plan how guests will leave, such as a recessional song or a quiet exit.

AT THE VENUE

- [ ] A greeter at the door to help people feel welcome.
- [ ] Extra chairs near the back for people who arrive late.
- [ ] A quiet room or corner for family.
- [ ] Water and tissues in several spots.
- [ ] Clear signs for restrooms, food, and the memory table.
- [ ] A place for coats, umbrellas, and winter boots in cold or wet weather.

RENTALS AND SUPPLIES

- [ ] Chairs sized to the number of people seated for the program.
- [ ] Tables for food, the memory table, and the guest book.
- [ ] Linens in calm colors.
- [ ] Serving equipment such as chafing dishes and coffee urns.
- [ ] Plates, cups, and utensils, or a rental set for easier cleanup.
- [ ] A tent or canopy if the gathering is outdoors.

PART 5

Memory Table Ideas

A memory table helps guests connect with the person you are honoring. Choose a few items, not everything.

Item	Why it works	Tip
Framed portrait	Gives the room a focal point	Choose a recent and happy photo
Photo collage or board	Tells their story over the years	Group by decade or theme
Favorite objects	Hobbies, tools, books, sports gear	Keep them sturdy and easy to handle
Handwritten recipes	Shares a family tradition	Print copies for guests to take
Guest book or memory cards	Collects stories and notes	Provide pens and a sturdy box
Candle or flowers	Creates a quiet corner	Use battery-operated candles if the venue prefers
Music playlist or record player	Brings their taste into the room	Check volume and sound
Flag, medals, or awards	Honors service or accomplishments	Place in a protected spot

PART 6

Repast Food Amounts

Rough guidelines for a meal or reception after the service. Families often bring dishes, so adjust as needed.

Item	25 guests	50 guests	100 guests
Main dishes	25 to 30 portions	50 to 60 portions	100 to 120 portions
Sandwiches or finger foods	50 to 75 pieces	100 to 150 pieces	200 to 300 pieces
Side dishes	3 to 4	4 to 5	5 to 6
Salads	1 large bowl	2 large bowls	3 to 4 large bowls
Desserts	30 to 40 pieces	60 to 80 pieces	120 to 160 pieces
Coffee	1 urn	2 urns	3 to 4 urns

Item	25 guests	50 guests	100 guests
Water, tea, and lemonade	2 to 3 gallons	4 to 6 gallons	8 to 12 gallons
Ice	20 lbs	40 lbs	80 lbs
Plates, cups, and napkins	50 each	100 each	200 each
Chairs	20 to 25	40 to 50	80 to 100
Tables for food and seating	4 to 5	7 to 9	14 to 18

PART 7

Who Does What

People often say, "Let me know what I can do." This table lets you answer them.

Task	Helper's name	Contact	Done
Greet guests and manage the guest book			
Welcome and lead the program			
Organize photos and slideshow			
Set up the memory table			
Coordinate food and drinks			
Pick up or accept deliveries			
Help older guests with seating			
Watch and entertain children			
Handle music and sound			
Collect flowers and gifts			
Manage cleanup and rentals			
Track thank-you notes			

PART 8

Budget Split

Rough shares to help you think through costs. Many families spend much less, and that is perfectly fine.



Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Food and drink	40%	$_____	Potluck contributions from family and friends can reduce this a lot.

Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Venue	20%	$_____	Community rooms and parks often cost less than event spaces.
Rentals (tables, chairs, linens, tent)	15%	$_____	Only rent what you need for the number of guests who will be there at once.
Flowers and decor	7%	$_____	A few meaningful arrangements are enough.
Printing (programs, memory cards)	4%	$_____	A simple one-page program works well.
Music and sound	4%	$_____	A speaker and a playlist can work for small gatherings.
Officiant or celebrant	5%	$_____	Ask about fees or donations in advance.
Contingency	5%	$_____	Set aside a small cushion for unexpected needs.

PART 9

Gathering Worksheet

Write things down here so you do not have to hold them in your head.

NAME OF THE PERSON BEING HONORED

DATE AND TIME

LOCATION AND ADDRESS

EXPECTED GUEST COUNT

OFFICIANT OR PERSON LEADING

SPEAKERS

MUSIC OR READINGS

FOOD AND DRINK PLAN

RENTAL COMPANY AND DELIVERY TIME

PARKING AND ACCESSIBILITY NOTES

MAIN FAMILY CONTACT AND PHONE

TOTAL BUDGET

NEXT STEP

Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.